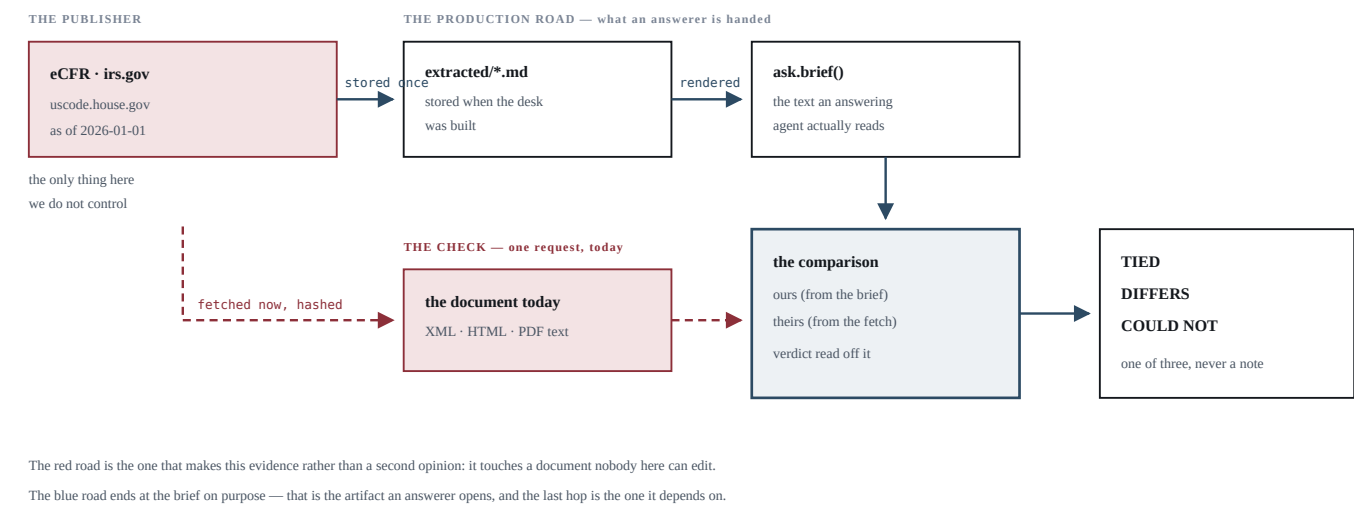


meals-and-entertainment

Every passage this desk hands to an answering agent, put back to the publisher that wrote it. **The question is not whether our tests pass.** It is whether the authority we serve is what the authority actually says — which no test in this repository can answer, because they all read the same stored files.



The same passage, two roads. They meet at the comparison, and the verdict is read off that block rather than written ahead of it.

The roster

0	0	44 of 44	6
DIFFERS	COULD NOT	TIED	SOURCES FETCHED LIVE

Of the 44 that tied, 44 matched the publisher's characters exactly and 0 matched only once whitespace was ignored — which is declared, and explained under what this does not prove.

The sample of one, worked end to end

The longest passage on this desk, because a long one has the most places to be wrong.

1 · THE FIGURE — AND WHERE A READER SEES IT

Not a row of a database: the paragraph of authority the desk hands an answering agent under the citation IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "Exception to the 50% Limit for Meals". It is read out of ask.brief(), which is the text that agent opens, and it is 2,568 characters long.

Your meal expense isn't subject to the 50% limit if the expense meets one of the following exceptions. Exception 1—expenses treated as compensation. In general, expenses for goods, services, and facilities, to the extent the expenses are treated by the taxpayer, with respect to entertainment, amusement, or recreation, as compensation to an employee and as wages to the employee for tax purposes. Exception 2—employee's reimbursed expenses. If you are an employee, you aren't subject to the 50% limit on expenses for which your employer reimburses you under an accountable plan. Accountable plans are discussed in chapter 6. Exception 3—self-employed reimbursed expenses. If you are self-employed, your deductible meal expenses aren't subject to the 50% limit if all of the following requirements are met. You have these expenses as an independent contractor. Your customer or client reimburses you or gives you an allowance for these expenses in connection with services you perform. You provide adequate records of these expenses to your customer or client. (See chapter 5.) In this case, your client or customer is subject to the 50% limit on the expenses. Example. You are a self-employed attorney who adequately accounts for meal expenses to a client who reimburses you for these expenses. You aren't subject to the limitation on meal expenses. If the client can deduct the expenses, the client is subject to the 50% limit. If you (as an independent contractor) have expenses for meals related to providing services for a client but don't adequately account for and seek reimbursement from the client for those expenses, you are subject to the 50% limit on non-entertainment-related meals and the entertainment-related meal expenses are nondeductible to you. Exception 4—recreational expenses for employees. You aren't subject to the 50% limit for expenses for recreational, social, or similar activities (including facilities) such as a holiday party or a summer picnic. Exception 5—advertising expenses. You aren't subject to the 50% limit if you provide meals to the general public as a means of advertising or promoting goodwill in the community. For example, neither the expense of sponsoring a television or radio show nor the expense of distributing free food and beverages to the general public is subject to the 50% limit. Exception 6—sale of meals. You aren't subject to the 50% limit if you actually sell meals to the public. For example, if you run a restaurant, your expense for the food you furnish to your customers isn't subject to the 50% limit.

2 · THE CALL — COPY-PASTABLE, WITH THE REAL VALUES IN IT

```
curl -sS --compressed "https://www.irs.gov/publications/p463"
```

Fetchd 2026-09-06 02:22:31Z · 848,610 bytes · SHA-256
7d3334557299e2899d01235a61b71d18a0896753bdcbf56857e286e15864bc03

3 · THE DERIVATION — WHAT HAPPENS BETWEEN THE TWO

The response is turned into plain text: an XML or HTML document has its inline tags closed up and its block tags turned into a space, a PDF is read page by page. Both sides are then folded the same way — Unicode normalised, and the typographic quotes and dashes publishers vary between renderings mapped to their plain forms. **Nothing else is changed.** The stored text either occurs in the publisher's document or it does not.

4 · THE INDEPENDENT SOURCE — CAPTURED, NOT SUMMARISED

The publisher's own words around the match, quoted verbatim out of the bytes whose hash is printed above. **A reader re-fetches that URL, recomputes the hash, and gets the same digits** — which is a check a photograph cannot offer.

...deduction is allowed for entertainment expenses. Exception to the 50% Limit for Meals Your meal expense isn't subject to the 50% limit if the expense meets one of the following exceptions. Exception 1-expenses treated as compensation. In general, expenses for goods, services, and facilities, to the extent the expenses are treated by the taxpayer, with respect to entertainment, amusement, or recreation, as compensation to an employee and as wages to the employee for tax purposes. Exception 2-employee's reimbursed expenses. If you are an employee, you aren't subject to the 50% limit on expenses for which your employer reimburses you under an accountable plan. Accountable plans are discussed in chapter 6. Exception 3-self-employed reimbursed expenses. If you are self-employed, your deductible meal expenses aren't subject to the 50% limit if all of the following requirements are met. You have these expenses as an independent contractor. Your customer or client reimburses you or gives you an allowance for these expenses in connection with services you perform. You provide adequate records of these expenses to your customer or client. (See chapter 5.) In this case, your client or customer is subject to the 50% limit on the expenses. Example. You are a self-employed attorney who adequately accounts for meal expenses to a client who reimburses you for these expenses. You aren't subject to the limitation on meal expenses. If the client can deduct the expenses, the client is subject to the 50% limit. If you (as an independent contractor) have expenses for meals related to providing services for a client but don't adequately account for and seek reimbursement from the client for those expenses, you are subject to the 50% limit on non-entertainment-related meals and the entertainment-related meal expenses are nondeductible to you. Exception 4-recreational expenses for employees. You aren't subject to the 50% limit for expenses for recreational, social, or similar activities (including facilities) such as a holiday party or a summer picnic. Exception 5-advertising expenses. You aren't subject to the 50% limit if you provide meals to the general public as a means of advertising or promoting goodwill in the community. For example, neither the expense of sponsoring a television or radio show nor the expense of distributing free food and beverages to the general public is subject to the 50% limit. Exception 6-sale of meals. You aren't subject to the 50% limit if you actually sell meals to the public. For example, if you run a restaurant, your expense for the food you furnish to your customers isn't subject to the 50% limit. Individuals subject to "hours of service" limits. You can deduct a higher percentage of your meal expenses while traveling away from your tax home if the meals take place during or incident to any period subject to the Department of Transportation's "hours of...

5 · THE COMPARISON

ours	(ask.brief → IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "Exception to the 50% Limi)
	2,568 characters
theirs	(https://www.irs.gov/publications/p463)
	2,568 of them found, verbatim, in the document fetched above
diff	none

TIED — the publisher’s characters exactly

Every passage on this desk

VERDICT	CITATION	CHARS	HOW / WHY
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(a)	840	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(b)(1)	667	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(b)(2)	764	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(c)	446	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(d)	901	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-2(e)	84	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(a)	716	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(b)(1)(i)	1,591	exact

VERDICT	CITATION	CHARS	HOW / WHY
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(b)(1)(ii)	1,388	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(b)(1)(iii)	1,226	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(b)(2)	194	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-11(c)	154	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(a)(1)	475	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(a)(2)	311	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(a)(4)(i)	450	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(a)(4)(ii)	280	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(a)(4)(iii)	725	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(b)(1)	272	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(b)(2)	430	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(b)(3)	318	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(b)(8)	173	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(b)(9)	410	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(1)	295	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(i)(A)	814	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(i)(B)	920	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(i)(D)	954	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(ii)(A)	872	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(iii)(A)	1,752	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(iv)(A)	552	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-12(c)(2)(v)(A)	1,036	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5(c)(2)(iii)(A)	418	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5(c)(2)(iii)(B)	1,357	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5(f)(4)(i)	1,362	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5(j)(1)	529	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5T(a)	1,466	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5T(b)(1)	332	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5T(b)(2)	862	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.274-5T(b)(3)	998	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "50% Limit" – costs to include or exclude	240	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "50% Limit" – taking turns paying for meals	235	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "50% Limit" – the general rule	496	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "Exception to the 50% Limit for Meals"	2,568	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "Proving business purpose"	806	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 463 (2025), "What Are Adequate Records?"	1,616	exact

The sources, and that they can disagree with us

- **S1** — Treasury Regulation § 1.274-12 — Limitation on deductions for certain food or beverage expenses paid or incurred after December 31, 2017
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-01-01/title-26.xml?section=1.274-12>
- **S2** — Treasury Regulation § 1.274-11 — Disallowance of deductions for certain entertainment, amusement, or recreation expenditures paid or incurred after December 31, 2017
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-01-01/title-26.xml?section=1.274-11>
- **S3** — Treasury Regulation § 1.162-2 — Traveling expenses
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-01-01/title-26.xml?section=1.162-2>
- **S4** — Treasury Regulation § 1.274-5 — Substantiation requirements
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-01-01/title-26.xml?section=1.274-5>
- **S5** — Treasury Regulation § 1.274-5T — Substantiation requirements (temporary)
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-01-01/title-26.xml?section=1.274-5T>
- **S6** — IRS Publication 463 (2025) — Travel, Gift, and Car Expenses
<https://www.irs.gov/publications/p463>

Not one of these is ours. None is a cache, a fixture or a second copy of our own record — which is the test the tie-out skill puts first: **could this disagree with me?** Each one can, and two of them did.

How to run this yourself

Every step below has the real values already in it. Nothing here needs me.

1 · RE-RUN THE WHOLE CHECK

```
cd desk && python -B tools/tieout.py
```

It fetches every source live and writes `tie-outs/findings.json`. Expect it to take a few minutes: it pauses between requests rather than hammering the publishers.

2 · REBUILD THESE DOCUMENTS FROM THAT RUN

```
cd desk && python -B tools/tieout_exhibit.py
```

3 · CHECK ONE LINE BY HAND, WITHOUT EITHER SCRIPT

Take any row in the roster, fetch its URL, and look for the text yourself:

```
curl -sS --compressed "https://www.irs.gov/publications/p463" | shasum -a 256
```

If that hash matches the one printed with the exemplar above, you are reading the same bytes this document read. Then search the document for the passage — the desk prints it under that citation in the brief:

```
cd desk && python -B -c "import sys; sys.path.insert(0, '.'); import ask, record, pathlib; \
print(ask.brief('show me', record.load(pathlib.Path('desks/meals-and-entertainment'))))" | less
```

What it found

Two differences in 533 passages, and a defect in the record that no difference would have shown.

- **Right text, wrong link — three passages.** The rewards desk stores § 6041, § 6041A, § 6050W and § 6071 under one source whose recorded URL is the House's granule for **§ 6041 only**. A reader following that link finds the first and not the other three; the "6041A" and "6050W" they see on that page are § 6041's own cross-references. All three bodies are **verbatim correct** on their own granules, so nothing served was wrong and no test could have caught it — the numbers were right and the citation pointed somewhere that does not carry them. **Only following the link finds this.** The checker now resolves each statute citation to its own granule; the record's source URL is still under-covering and is a fix for the desk.
- **A partial quotation that does not say it is one.** Publication 583's sentence has two branches and the cash desk stores the second without marking the omission. The split is right — the branches have opposite answers, which is the defect #264 found — but an answerer reading the passage cannot tell a branch was removed.
- **A publisher's interface text inside a quotation.** irs.gov appends the word **PDF** to links that point at PDFs, and it sits mid-sentence on the tangible-property page. Ours drops it, which reads correctly and is not what the page literally shows.

And what it did not find is the point of running it. 531 of 533 passages are, character for character, what the publisher publishes today. That was an assumption this morning and it is a measurement now.

What I got wrong

The first run reported 88 differences and 34 of them were mine. The extractor replaced every markup tag with a space, so eCFR's election</I>—(1) came back as election - (1) and 601.601(d)(2)(ii)(<I>b</I>) as (b). A checker that invents differences is worse than no checker, because somebody goes and "fixes" the record to match it. Inline tags now close up and only block tags become a space.

Then it reported 18, and 16 of those were mine too. pypdf reads a kerned two-column IRS page as Y ou and hyphenates infor-mation across a line break, and irs.gov puts block markup inside a sentence. Those are rendering artefacts of the extractor, not differences in what was published — so the comparison now runs twice, and the exhibit says which pass carried each line rather than quietly folding them together.

I could not capture the sources as photographs, and the skill asks for photographs.

This machine's browser cannot reach the publishers even when pointed at the egress proxy

— ERR_CONNECTION_RESET — while the HTTP client reaches them fine. Attempted, failed, recorded. What is here instead is the document itself: its SHA-256, its length, the moment it was fetched and the publisher's own words quoted around each match. For text that is the stronger evidence, because a reader can recompute the hash and a screenshot cannot be re-verified at all.

What this does not prove

- **It proves the words, not the reading.** That § 1.263(a)-1(f)(1)(ii)(D) says \$500 is now established. Whether \$500 is the number that governs a client is a question about Notice 2015-82 and about the firm's election, and no fetch settles it.
- **It proves containment, not completeness.** The check asks whether our passage occurs in the publisher's document. It does not ask whether we stored the *whole* of what that citation covers — a passage could be a true fragment of a paragraph whose second half changes its meaning. Publication 583 above is exactly that failure caught by accident, not by design.
- **The whitespace-ignoring pass can hide a genuinely missing space.** 13 lines tied only on that pass. Each is named in the roster as spacing so nobody has to take it on trust.
- **The regulations were fetched as of 2026-01-01, not today.** eCFR's versioner refuses a future date and this is the last date known good on it. A regulation amended between that date and now would not show here.
- **One reading, not two.** The skill asks for a second rendering where one exists — the XML and the rendered page, the PDF and the HTML. Only one rendering per source was read. A digit or a word wrong in *both* our copy and the one rendering we read would pass.
- **Nothing here touches whether a desk answers well.** This is about the authority it is given. A desk with a perfect corpus can still reason badly from it, and that is what the scoreboard is for.